

THE MOTOWN UNIVERSE

Executive Development Memo #003 — Leadership, Distributor & Acquirer
An alternate-reality “what if” • Fidelity Rating: 100% • Nerf Tolerance: 0%

1. The Decisions

SPEARHEAD: **Suzanne de Passe** — President, Motown Productions

FOUNDER ROLE: **Berry Gordy** — Chairman Emeritus

DISTRIBUTOR: **Paramount Pictures**

EVENTUAL ACQUIRER: **Universal Pictures (NBCUniversal)**

2. The Blueprint Map

Role	MCU (real world)	TMU (our universe)
Franchise lead	Kevin Feige, President of Marvel Studios	Suzanne de Passe, President of Motown Productions
Founder figure	Stan Lee, Chairman Emeritus of Marvel	Berry Gordy, Chairman Emeritus of Motown Productions
Early distributor	Paramount Pictures	Paramount Pictures
Acquirer	The Walt Disney Company (announced 2009)	Universal Pictures / NBCUniversal

3. The Spearhead: Suzanne de Passe

Position: **President of Motown Productions**. This is the same title Kevin Feige held at Marvel Studios, and she held it in real life.

- **She's done this job before.** She ran Motown Productions historically. Putting her back in charge is the most accurate choice possible.
- **She has a proven eye for talent.** She rose from Berry Gordy's creative assistant to a top Motown executive, and she worked closely with the Jackson 5 early in their Motown career.
- **She has Oscar and Emmy credits.** She shared an Oscar nomination for writing *Lady Sings the Blues* (1972). She produced the Emmy-winning *Motown 25* (1983) and *Lonesome Dove* (1989).

- **She has already made a faithful Motown biopic.** She was executive producer of NBC's miniseries *The Temptations* (1998). That's proof she can put real Motown history on screen.
- **She has everyone's trust.** The artists, the songwriters and Gordy all know her. That access is what makes the Fidelity Mandate possible.

4. The Founder: Berry Gordy

Position: **Chairman Emeritus of Motown Productions.** This mirrors Stan Lee's honorary title at Marvel.

- He's the founder and final authority on how accurate the story is. When the history is in doubt, his memoir *To Be Loved* (1994) and his own memory are the first references.
- He doesn't run the studio day to day. De Passe does. That is how the MCU split its founder and its franchise lead.

5. The Distributor: Paramount Pictures

- **It matches the MCU exactly.** Paramount distributed Marvel Studios' early films before Disney took over.
- **Motown and Paramount already worked together.** Paramount released Motown Productions' *Lady Sings the Blues* (1972) and *Mahogany* (1975). Choosing Paramount picks up a real partnership where it left off.
- **It's a full-size studio.** One of Hollywood's oldest majors backs every release, with worldwide reach.

6. The Eventual Acquirer: Universal Pictures (NBCUniversal)

- **It follows the Disney–Marvel pattern.** After the first film proves the franchise works, a major studio buys Motown Productions outright and eventually takes over distribution. Paramount keeps the films it already has contracts for, just as it did with Marvel.
- **Universal has deep Motown history.** MCA, Universal's parent company at the time, bought Motown Records in 1988. Universal Pictures also co-produced Motown Productions' *The Wiz* (1978).
- **The music lives in the Universal family.** The Motown masters are owned by Universal Music Group. It has been a separate company from NBCUniversal since 2004, but they share a name and history. That makes Universal the natural home for the films that use those songs.
- **It brings the story full circle.** The label, its music and its movies all end up under the Universal name.

Open item

We'll set the exact date the acquisition is announced in a later memo, once the film slate is decided.

TMU is a fan-made alternate-reality concept. It has no connection to Motown Records, Universal, Paramount, Marvel Studios or Disney. The people named are real, and their roles here are fictional.